WHY DO WE DREAM?

You have, on average, a whopping 1,825 dreams every year, though you may not remember them. This is because you have no self-awareness in dreams. The brain's frontal lobes, which produce the sense of self, are mostly shut down. A dream is a series of images, thoughts, or emotions that take the form of a story during sleep. We can find ourselves in any situation in a dream, wondering afterward why we were even there in the first place.

REM SLEEP

There are two main types of sleep. Rapid eye movement (REM) sleep comes and goes during the night and totals about one fifth of sleep time. In REM sleep, your muscles are relaxed, but your brain is highly active and your closed eyes move quickly from side to side. This is when we dream. Electrical activity recorded in the brain during REM sleep has been shown to be similar to that recorded during waking hours.

NON-REM SLEEP

During non-REM sleep, your brain is very quiet, but your body starts moving around. The body uses this time to repair itself after all of its efforts during the day. Every night, we move between periods of REM and non-REM sleep, which helps prepare ourselves for the next day. When we first go to sleep, dreams last about ten minutes, but as we get closer to waking up in the morning, dreams can last up to 45 minutes.

FOLLOW YOUR DREAMS

DREAM THEORIES

Some researchers suggest that dreams serve no real purpose at all, and there is no point in trying to understand why we do dream. Others continue to put forward theories to explain why we dream. Here are some of them:

LONG-TERM MEMORIES

One scientific theory is that dreams are mixed versions of the events and thoughts we have while we are awake. This is the process that ensures the day's memories turn into long-term memories.

DAILY HOUSEKEEPING

Another theory also links the events of the day with what we dream about at night. The idea is that dreaming is a form of housekeeping, clearing away the day's mental clutter so that the mind is ready for the next day. A clear mind allows the brain to absorb new information without overloading.